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The Obama Effect

The first time I watched Barack Obama speak at an election rally a year-and-a-half ago on my television set, I sat mesmerised by his oratory, his super cool demeanour and his catchy slogan of 'Change We Can Believe In' which later morphed to the more powerful: "Yes We Can." In many ways he reminded me of the late Rajiv Gandhi when he was on the campaign trail for the historic 1984 general elections soon after Indira Gandhi, the then prime minister and his mother, was assassinated. Rajiv may not have had Obama's elocution skills, but brought a similar freshness, youthful energy and the promise of big change. It was different that after a Camelot period, mid-way through his term Rajiv started becoming part of the political system he had hated and vowed to change. Yet till Rajiv's life was brutally cut short in 1991, he always held the hope of making a better India.

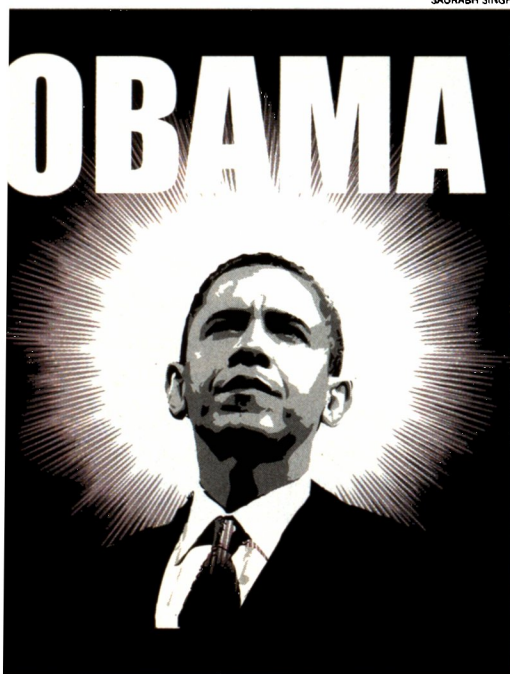
Now that Obama has won a historic vote that transcended race, age, gender and even experience, his actions when he takes over in January as US President for the next four years would not only impact America but most of the world including India. If Rajiv faced the twin threats of a divided India and a failing economy, Obama faces equally humongous challenges. He has to handle the question of the exit of US troops in Iraq and Afghanistan without denting American credibility, strategic interests or compromising on the war on terror. But his even bigger test is to pull his country out of the frightening financial quagmire that it has fallen into. Both of these are extraordinary challenges any incoming leader has to face and the world will watch with bated breath as Obama gets down to tackling them.

For India, Obama's actions in the Senate when the US India nuclear deal was being voted where his tough amendment on fuel guarantees almost crippled it caused consternation. Subsequently his negative statements on the campaign trail about outsourcing and issuing work

visas has made us cautious in our optimism over his victory. And his recent statement about active US involvement in resolving the Kashmir crisis has caused nervousness in South Block. India has always enjoyed better relations with the US when a Republican was at the helm and George W. Bush proved to be, as Prime Minister Manmohan Singh vouched, the best American President we have ever had. The last four years saw considerable momentum gather in relations between India and US. Now with even the nuclear irritant out of the way, Obama has the rare opportunity of setting aside his reservations and working towards realising the full potential of relations between the two countries. Apart from furthering strategic ties including defence and hi-tech purchases, there is much that India and US can do together in the fields of climate change, space, health and agriculture. So can Obama do it? I am hoping he would live up to his campaign slogan.



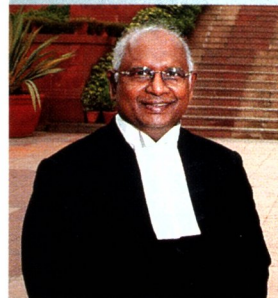
OBAMA, LIKE RAJIV GANDHI, BRINGS THE PROMISE OF BIG CHANGE. THE CONCERN IS, CAN HE DELIVER?



SAURABH SINGH

SIGNPOSTS

AWARDED: To Chief Justice of India **K.G. Balakrishnan**, the first V.K. Krishna Menon Award for his fight against corruption in the judicial system and



for espousing social causes. The award is instituted by the V.K. Krishna Menon Foundation in London.

APPOINTED: Economist **Raghuram G. Rajan** as the honorary economic adviser to the prime minister. Rajan is a former chief economist of the IMF and a professor of finance at University of Chicago.

WON: By **Gagan Narang**, the gold medal in the men's 10 m air rifle event with a world record score in the World Cup Finals in Bangkok.



WON: By **Thokchom Nanao Singh**, the gold medal at the inaugural AIBA Youth World Boxing Championships in Guadalajara, Mexico.

